

Transcript of Treatment Video (English Translation):

Happily Under-Insured Ever After? The Role of Beliefs in Household Specialization

Duration: 5:48 minutes

Sandra: Divorce has consequences all the way into the nursing home

[The video shows Sandra in her apartment, seated directly in front of the camera, alongside scenes of her organizing her children's belongings, preparing coffee, and working on her computer.]

I am a mother of two daughters; they are 11 and 13 years old. I live in the canton of [...], in the [...] region, and I work in the Zurich area for a large company. I separated from my ex-husband four years ago and have now been officially divorced for two years.

I always thought that this only happens to other people, although one has the statistics in mind.

At some point, the moment came when I felt: it just doesn't work anymore for the future. Too many things simply no longer fit for me.

The children have their main residence with me, but they are also very regularly with their dad, and they have a very good relationship.

When the children were born, I reduced my workload from 100% to 40%.

The classic model—I ended up in it without actively thinking about it.

There is a pension fund equalization between my ex-husband and me for the years we were married. But for the years before, when we were together and so on, there isn't.

His salary at the time of the divorce is significantly higher than mine, and that is also due to his high workload.

We both wanted children, and we both wanted the children to grow up with a lot of warmth and nurturing at home.

I was absolutely not aware of that afterwards — in the case you always hope won't happen — I would actually be the one paying the price financially in the long run.

And that is where there is a clear difference between my ex-husband and me: he essentially continues on his path, and for me the financial burden remains for years to come.

The financial means available to me are reduced—probably for the rest of my life.

When we decided to become parents and hoped that we could have children, I did not think for a single minute that my workload would later directly affect my pension.

I simply did not have that on my radar.

If someone had told me back then that, from a financial point of view, I should not work below a 70% workload, I would probably have taken note of it.

At the time, I thought that 40% was already a good thing and did not really question it. Today I have to say that 40% is actually quite little.

Claudia & Thomas: Talk it through and plan ahead

[The video shows the couple seated side by side at their kitchen table, speaking directly to the camera, alongside scenes of them preparing food with their children in the kitchen.]

Thomas: I'm Thomas [...], 45, and I currently work full-time at Schutz und Rettung. We are in a cohabiting relationship: a family with two children, but we are not married.

Claudia: My name is Claudia [...], 44, I am a commercial clerk. When [...] was born, our first daughter, we split it in a way that I reduced to 70% and Thomas continued working 100% at the fire brigade. After one year, I felt that was a bit too little time at home with our daughter and then reduced to 50%. In the last few months, I increased again to 70%, and I'm also happy to be able to work a bit more again.

Thomas: With Claudia reducing her workload, we had to think about how to arrange things financially as well. We had a notary, an acquaintance of ours, who took the time and sat down with us and mapped out the whole timeline. All eventualities—separation, death, accident, retiring together. So the nice and the less nice moments in life.

Yes, so for me it felt fine, it was okay.

Claudia: For me as well, and it sounds really silly, but for me it's kind of self-evident that one can talk about this openly.

Thomas: If you can sort it out in peaceful times, then it's easier afterwards. I've just seen a lot of divorces around me that didn't end very nicely. At the moment, I compensate half of [Claudia's] loss in income.

Claudia: Thomas pays me compensation for the loss in income, specifically 15% [of an FTE]. And I cover the other 15%. In addition, he pays me a compensation that I can invest in the third pillar [retirement account].

Thomas: 100% of the pension fund loss [second pillar retirement account].

Claudia: He transfers that to me, and I invest it myself in my personal third pillar. In the end, it's about my livelihood. I think here you're allowed to be quite selfish and say: this is important to me so that I can also be secure in the future. For me, the goal is that if a separation were to happen, I am in the same position as if I had worked 100%. That means that I don't have a gap in the pension fund. Well, I do have a gap in the pension fund, but I set aside the money in the third pillar.

What would you advise others?

Claudia: I recommend to every woman that you talk about this very openly. That you discuss the important points together. From the beginning and not only when it's too late. No matter what kind of solution you aim for, but that it works for both and that it is fair.

Sandra: If a young couple or young families were listening to me now and asked me what I would recommend, then I would say that they should actively discuss how to divide workload [in the workforce]. And not only in terms of how you can organize childcare right now, but really also what financial consequences this has all the way through to retirement.